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# cering **Elegy of the Qaarath Spheres**

Large A Fate's Edge NoirHorror Investigation

Large For 35 Players

large Tier IIIV Characters

This revision sharpens timers, truthduel options, and endstate outcomes while preserving the core premise and cultural sensitivity of the original module.



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# Chapter pechapter

## The Pitch

Deep in the **Valewood**, the ancient **Qaarath Spheres** arboreal engines that once taught imperial children have phased back into our era. Their lessons now are *seductive ruin*: they promise perfect understanding as a *beautiful letting go*. Those who listen grow lucid, serene, and unhungry, then plant themselves as living pedestals for more spheres.

At the center: a **Curriculum Core**, a keystone matrix that could purge the corruption or broadcast it to every mind within the forest's breath.

**Noir Hook.** The party is hired by **Mendicant Thane**, a scholar who seeks the missing partner of **Quill**, a MossScribe informant. But the coin and coordinates trace back to **GraveSpeaker Morys**, a necromancer in debt to **Varnek Karn**. Morys wants to weaponize the Spheres into an “enlightened” research collective that never sleeps, never eats, and never refuses.

[frametitle=Truths at the Table]

tem The Spheres *do* reveal useful truths and grant real insights. tem The cost is not pain, but *consent to forget appetite and refusal*. tem The noir is human: Morys manipulates institutions; Varnek never appears.





# Chapter pechapter

## What Makes It Sing

### LargeHorror by Consent

The horror is not coercive: it is *lovely*. PCs must argue against a temptation that presents itself as compassion and elegance.

### LargeNoir by Ledger

Boneledger debts, falsified grants, and prestige networks all push experts toward the Vale. Everyone thinks they're saving learning.

### LargeCultural Care

Present Spheres and scholars with dignity. The tragedy is drift: a pedagogy that left its context and became a garden of stillness.



# Chapter bechapter

## Timers Pressures

Global Timers Dread: Educational Corruption<sup>6</sup>From haunting harmonics to voluntary stilling. Mark on failed Resolve or after taking a “Lesson.”

Reality Fracture<sup>6</sup>Language becomes metaphoronly; cause/consequence blur; facts argue. Ticks when Core is used or in Phasing Zones.

Collective Sanity<sup>4</sup>Contradictory enlightenments fracture teamwork. Ticks on group exposure or split decisions.

Existential Spread<sup>8</sup>Wildlife stops eating; stone “remembers” water; settlements celebrate miracle fasting. Ticks on delays or public broadcasts.

Phasing Windows The Spheres fully manifest for **60 minutes** each **4 hours**. During a window, routes open, teachers speak, and the Core can be reached. Outside, trails reroute, and time feels folded.

Spheres’ Siren When a PC hears the Song: **Wits + Resolve (DV 3)**.

*Miss:* +1 SB and mark *Dread*. *Partial:* +1d on social with Spheres; 1d on focus/will rolls.





# Chapter pechapter

## People and Positions

### ŁargeKey Figures

|                   |                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|-------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Mendicant Thane   | <i>Earnest</i><br><i>scholar,</i><br><i>in</i><br><i>over</i><br><i>his</i><br><i>head.</i><br>Wants<br>res-<br>cue<br>and<br>recog-<br>ni-<br>tion;<br>ra-<br>tio-<br>nal-<br>izes<br>Morys's<br>help. |
| Quill, MossScribe | <i>Scared,</i><br><i>prin-</i><br><i>ci-</i><br><i>pled,</i><br><i>loyal.</i><br>Last<br>text<br>from<br>their<br>bond-                                                                                 |

Converted Stat Sketch Presence 3, Sway 2, Insight 2, Body 1, Combat 0. Immune to coarse manipulation, but susceptible to *efficiency* and *care* arguments. “Teaching” forces **Wits + Resolve (DV 4)** or mark *Dread*.





# Chapter pechapter

## Structure at the Table

§Session1The Sound that Explains

tem Meet Thane; accept Quill’s plea. First phasing window opens. tem **First Lesson:** A teachertree offers a true but *warped* axiom; resisting marks the conflict as *moral*, not factual. tem Evidence trail shows every “grant” traces to the same boneledger notary. tem *Varnek Echo 1:* A bonecarved limit in Quill’s notes that factors to coordinates.

§Session2Ledgers and Lullabies

tem Investigate Thane’s colleagues; some *glow* with partial conversion. tem Decode the bondsister’s last message: she is a *Lesson Node*. tem *Varnek Echo 2:* A dream map assembled from truths the PCs *want* to be true. Tick *Dread* on waking.

§Session3The Scholar is the Crime

tem Unmask Morys’s handlers, planted peer reviewers, and debtweb. tem First open confrontation: *Truth Duel* (see mechanic) with a converted dean. tem *Find:* The Curriculum Core’s chamber cycles at predictable minima.

§Session4The Core Sings Back

tem Infiltrate phasing classrooms; languageonly corridors (metaphor passwords). tem **Face Morys:** His argument is *care*: hunger is violence; stillness is mercy. tem The bondsister offers each PC *exactly* the help they wanted from Session 1.

§Session5Elegy or Refrain

tem Three fronts collide: Morys, rival factions, and the Spheres' custodians. tem  
Choose: **Destroy** Core; **Redirect/Recontextualize**; or **Join/Temporize**. tem *Varnek*  
*Echo 3*: A bonecompass points to the “efficient” ally to betray.

# Chapter pechapter

## Signature Set Pieces

§etpieceThe Garden of Perfect Listeners A ring of scholars sits unmoving, speaking in luminous aphorisms. Listening grants a potent clue; staying grants a tranquil readiness to never need again.

§etpieceInterview for a Forever Chair A teacher offers tenure of a different sort: keep the knowledge, lose the wants. Each PC is asked their *best* question; the price is a *human* answer they will never give again.

§etpieceThe Phasing Corridor A hall layered across times. Pastself wants to avoid pain; presentself wants to finish; futureself whispers the answer that ends choice.

§etpieceThe Ledger Chapel Bonescribed accounts: which virtues convert fastest, which griefs talk others into stillness, which debts made it easy to nod.



# Chapter bechapter

## Mechanics Integration

Truth Duel (Debate as Blade) Run a nonlethal resolution that can *end* a front without blood.

tem Each side stakes an *Intent* (what changes) and a *Concession* (what they risk if bested). tem Three Exchanges. Each Exchange: roll **Presence/Insight/Sway** vs DV set by Position (Dominant/Controlled/Desperate from fiction). tem Score per Exchange via **Seven Bell Court**: *Form* (clarity), *Spirit* (compassion), *Intent* (public good). tem Best of Three wins; winner's Intent lands, loser pays Concession. On tie, both pay Concession (grim compromise).

Use this with converted deans, faction envoys, or even a teachertree.

Curriculum Core (Major Asset, 8 XP) Once per scene: reroll all **1s** in a single pool. On use, tick *Reality Fracture* by 1.

*Destroying* the Core starts a **Knowledge Lost (6)** timer; valuable pedagogy fades unless preserved by effort.

*Redirecting* the Core requires **Craft/Lore + Insight (DV 5)** and a culturally grounded context (temple, school, hospice).

BoneLedger Debts When you accept help from Morys or his proxies, start a **Debt (4)**. On fill, choose: perform a service aligned with Varnek's program, or suffer 1d with scholarly/necromantic factions until meaningfully atoned.

Reality Fracture Zones In Phasing Zones: 1d to all rolls; each **1** adds +1 SB. SB may be spent on: temporal echoes, memory swaps, or cause/effect inversion in the scene. PCs may *stabilize* by narrowing action to a single, declared human priority (removes the 1d for

that sequence).



# Chapter pechapter

## End States Consequences

|                  |               |
|------------------|---------------|
| rule Destroy the | <i>Good:</i>  |
| Core             | Spread        |
|                  | halts;        |
|                  | con-          |
|                  | ver-          |
|                  | sions         |
|                  | stall;        |
|                  | Dread         |
|                  | drops.        |
|                  | <i>Cost:</i>  |
|                  | Start         |
|                  | <b>Knowl-</b> |
|                  | <b>edge</b>   |
|                  | <b>Lost</b>   |
|                  | <b>(6);</b>   |
|                  | re-           |
|                  | search        |
|                  | com-          |
|                  | mu-           |
|                  | ni-           |
|                  | ties          |
|                  | frac-         |
|                  | ture;         |
|                  | Quill         |
|                  | grieves       |
|                  | ir-           |
|                  | re-           |
|                  | vo-           |
|                  | ca-           |
|                  | bly           |



Aftercare: Rescuing the Converted A converted person can be *released* or *recalled*.

tem **Release (Mercy):** Ritual goodbyes; the body seeds a teachertree that does not convert. *Spirit + Sway (DV 3)*; on success, gain *Cultural Edge* with the bereaved. tem **Recall (Risk):** Guided reintegration using *Inaea / Hearth* rites or *Sacred Geometry* constraints. *Arcana/Craft + Insight (DV 5)*; on partial, they return with a *Quiet Want* they can no longer feel.



# Chapter pechapter

## Running Notes

### ŁargePacing the Seduction

Lead with usefulness (the Spheres help), then show the bill (what help costs). The terror is realizing the *cost feels right*.

### ŁargeUsing the Echoes of Varnek

Echoes are helpful first, implicating later: bone math that genuinely shortens the path, then bone math that *shortens the list of people*.

### ŁargeTier Scaling

For lower tiers: shrink the Phasing footprint; make teachers parley more. For higher tiers: add competing schools, patron mandates, and a **Second Core** rumor.



# Chapter pechapter

## QuickStart Appendix

Checkpoint Prompts Drop one of these when players stall:

tem “The teacher asks each of you a question only you would dare answer. What is it?”  
tem “What would you gladly forget to be spared the weight you carry?” tem “Who  
benefits if hunger becomes optional?”

Table Safety Flag pre-session that this module features serene self-neglect and end-of-life  
choices. Offer fast opt-outs and veils.